California Residency and Customer Address	Number	Page
	04.08.01	1 of 4

Revision Date:
August 1, 2026

Background:
A customer must reside in the state of California to be eligible for Medi-Cal. They must maintain up to date contact information to ensure they receive important information about their benefits and eligibility. Customers are required to report changes to their address information within ten days of the change.

Purpose:
The purpose of this section is to define residency requirements, explain how a customer may establish residency in California, and specify required actions when a customer uses a Post Office (P.O.) Box or a Commercial Mail Receiving Agency (CMRA) address. This section includes new guidance on updating customers' addresses based on information received from reliable third-party sources. This section was reformatted and renumbered.

Policy:
A. Establishing California Residency
California residency is a condition of eligibility for Medi-Cal and must be verified at initial application. Once California residency is established, it continues until residency is established in another state or country as defined by Medi-Cal Program Guide (MPG) 04.08.03.

If staff become aware of information that contradicts the customer's claim of California residency, verification must be requested. If the information provided does not resolve the discrepancy, a fraud referral will be initiated. If a determination is made that the customer is not a resident of the state, staff must clearly narrate all facts in the journal entry.

B. Use of P.O Box, CMRA or Alternate Address to Establish California Residency
Although customers must meet residency requirements, they are not required to have a fixed address. A P.O. Box or CMRA address can be used as a mailing address, but it does not satisfy the residency requirement.

C. Job Commitment or Seeking Employment
California residency may be established during the period of employment or while seeking employment even if they plan to return to a residence in another state when they reside in California. A person who commutes to California for employment while living in another state or country is not considered a resident of California.

D. Households with Separate Residences
Household members may establish separate residences with no break in marital or familial ties. In these situations, only household members who meet the California residency requirements are eligible for Medi-Cal.

E. Children Living with Their Parents
Children living with their parents will have their residency determined as that of their parents. Parents who do not meet the California residency requirements may establish California residency for their children if both of the following conditions are met:

- The parents:
  - Intend for their children to remain in California on a permanent basis.
  - Have arranged for the children to remain in California independent of the parents.

F. Unusual Circumstances

California residency may be established when a customer:

- Is on parole from a correctional facility or other institution.
- Is living within the boundaries of California on land owned or leased by the Federal Government.
- Receives Public Assistance from another state or county if the issuing agency knows that the customer is a resident of California and sends the benefits directly to a California address in the customer's name.

G. Acceptable Address Sources for Medi-Cal Only Cases

To ensure that eligible customers do not lose coverage when their address changes, staff must act on updated in-state address information from the following reliable third-party sources:

- Mail returned to the county by the United States Postal Service (USPS) with an in-state forwarding address.
- The USPS National Change of Address (NCOA) database, and
- Updated member address information received by a Medi-Cal Managed Care Plan (MCP), provided that the information was directly from or verified with the member to the MCP.

If…	then…
the county receives an updated in-state address for the primary applicant from a reliable third-party source,	staff must update the mailing and physical address in the case record for all household members who share the same mailing and physical address as the primary applicant.
a household member, such as an adult child or spouse, has a different address on record,	their address will not be updated unless the county has been informed that they now reside at the same address.
the county receives an updated in-state address from a reliable third-party source for someone other than the primary applicant, and the update does not indicate if it applies to the entire household,	staff must follow the process outlined in Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46 Address Discrepancies and Loss of Contact. If the customer does not respond, the address cannot be updated. The case record must retain the last known address confirmed by the customer.

In cases where customers have separate mailing and physical addresses or a P.O. Box, the address may be updated as follows:

If…	then…
the physical and mailing address in the case record are different at the time the in-state address update is received,	staff must only update the mailing address.

the mailing address is a P.O. Box, and the physical address is different in the case record at the time the in-state address update is received,	staff must not update either address. Follow the good faith effort processes outlined in Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46 Address Discrepancies and Loss of Contact.
the updated address indicates a P.O. Box as the forwarding address,	staff must not treat the P.O. Box as an in-state forwarding address. The addresses must not be updated. Staff must follow the good faith effort processes outlined in Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46 Address Discrepancies and Loss of Contact.

Note: When the updated address is outside of the county, staff must complete an intercounty transfer (ICT) if no other eligibility information is needed. Refer to MPG 03.02 for guidance on ICTs. There should be no interruption in benefits during this process.

For cases where more than one program is active, staff must follow the program hierarchy before updating the case. Refer to CalWORKs Program Guide (CPG) 42-400.A and CalFresh Program Guide (CFPG) 63-152 for guidance.

H. Vulnerable or Sensitive Cases:
Staff must not update the address for families with a domestic violence flag in the California Statewide Automated Welfare System (CalSAWS) until they can confirm the address change through the Address Discrepancies procedures outlined in Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46. If the household does not report the change voluntarily, staff must verify it at the next renewal. Eligibility shall not be discontinued for not reporting an address change. If staff are unable to confirm the new address, the address on the case record must remain as the last known address confirmed by the customer.

Staff must not update the address for customers who are incarcerated or for cases in which a household member is incarcerated. Staff must confirm the newly updated address using the process outlined in the Ex Parte Unsuccessful in Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46.

I. Address Updates for the Safe at Home (SAH) Program
Staff may only change the address for customers in the SAH program when the customer provides and confirms the new address directly and indicates their participation in the SAH program has been terminated.

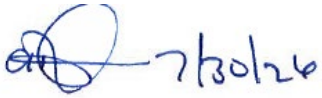
Procedures:
Refer to Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46 Address Discrepancies and Loss of Contact.

Program Impacts:
None

References:
ACWDL 93-29, 95-47, 96-27, 25-06
MEDIL I 14-20, I 14-29, I 14-44

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by July 31, 2029.

Approval for Release:



Alberto Banuelos, Ph.D., Interim Director
Self-Sufficiency Services

Revision Date:
August 1, 2026

Background:
Customers residing in California for purposes of attending school may meet Medi-Cal residency requirements. Similarly, customers may remain Medi-Cal eligible if they leave California temporarily to attend school in another state.

Purpose:
The purpose of this section is to provide guidance when determining California residency for customers who are living in California to attend school and those who attend school out-of-state. This section was reformatted and renumbered.

Policy:
A. Students Who Come to California to Attend School
Students from another state or country who are residing in California while attending school may qualify for Medi-Cal if they are a resident of California. Students who commute into California to attend school from another state or country do not meet the California residency requirement.

If a student applies for Medi-Cal and is receiving Medicaid in another state, their benefits must be discontinued as soon as administratively possible. An eligible student cannot receive Medicaid coverage in more than one state at the same time.

All other Medi-Cal eligibility rules and requirements apply in cases with customers who come to California to attend school.

B. Students Attending School in Another State
Students who leave California to attend school temporarily in another state must report their temporary leave to the county.

Medi-Cal Eligibility Data System (MEDS) must continue to reflect the California address to which they plan to return. Temporary absence from California does not have a specific timeframe requirement, however a 60-day absence may lead to a presumption that the customer is no longer a California resident. Absences over 60 days may require additional follow-up.

Students attending school in another state can choose to discontinue benefits in California and apply for Medicaid in the state where they are attending school. If this occurs, Medi-Cal must be discontinued as soon as administratively possible.

C. Impact to Parent/Caretaker Relatives of Out-of-State Students
Students who move out-of-state to attend school have no impact on the family Medi-Cal case if the student is still claimed as a tax dependent by their parent(s). Students who are claimed as tax dependents must provide the applicable tax household and income information when they apply for Medi-Cal.

When a student who temporarily moves out of state is the only child on the case, their parent(s) will maintain their parent/caretaker linkage if the student meets the requirements to be considered a dependent child. These requirements are:

- The child meets the age requirements.
- The parent(s) remain the primary caregiver(s) and is/are financially responsible for the child.
- The child is still considered to be residing with their parents.

D. Out-of-State Coverage

Medi-Cal covers emergency services for customers who are temporarily absent from the state. When emergency services are received out-of-state, the provider must agree to accept Medi-Cal and must meet the requirements for becoming a Medi-Cal provider. Emergency services are provided in the United States. Only emergency services requiring hospitalization are provided in Canada and Mexico.

Procedures:
None

Program Impacts:
None

References:
ACWDL 15-23

Sunset Date:
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Approval for Release:

7/30/26

Alberto Banuelos, Ph.D., Interim Director
Self-Sufficiency Services

Temporary Absence and Loss of California Residency	Number	Page
	04.08.03	1 of 2

Revision Date:
August 1, 2026

Background:
Individuals may be temporarily absent from the state of California without affecting their residency status depending on the duration of the absence.

Purpose:
The purpose of this section is to provide guidance on the treatment of temporary absences and loss of California residency. This section was reformatted and renumbered.

Policy:
A. Absence for 60 Days or Less
Customers who are temporarily absent from the state of California for a period of 60 days or less will not have their residency status affected. Staff will presume an absence of 60 days or less to be a temporary absence unless there is evidence to the contrary.

Staff must accept applications or redeterminations from customers who are temporarily absent from the state for 60 days or less.

B. Absence for More than 60 Days
When a customer is absent from the state for more than 60 days, staff will presume they intend to establish residency outside of California, unless they provide a written statement which states both:

- An intent to return to California.
- The existence of one of the following circumstances:
  - Illness or emergency which prohibits the customer's return to California.
  - The customer lives with family members who are California residents and are physically present in the state.
  - The customer maintains California housing arrangements.

When a customer is absent from the state for more than 60 days, staff must request verification of residency.

C. Loss of California Residency
A customer is considered to have loss of California residency when they leave the state and take any of the following actions in another state:

- Purchases, leases, or rents a residence.
- Becomes employed.
- Obtains an out-of-state driver's license.
- Applies for aid in another state.

The loss of residency will be considered verified unless there is evidence to the contrary. When a customer loses residency, Medi-Cal benefits will be discontinued effective the last day of the month in which residency was terminated or the last day of the following month, whichever allows for sufficient 10-day notice.

D. Death During Absence from the State

A customer who dies during an absence from the state will be considered a resident of California if there is evidence that they met the residency requirements at the time of death.

Procedures:

None

Program Impacts:

None

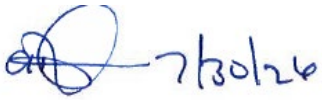
References:

ACWDL 93-29, 95-47, 26-04

Sunset Date:

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Approval for Release:



Alberto Banuelos, Ph.D., Interim Director
Self-Sufficiency Services

Loss of Customer Contact	Number	Page
	04.08.04	1 of 3

Revision Date:
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Background:
Medi-Cal may be denied or discontinued for loss of contact only after reasonable attempts are made to contact the customer. Staff must confirm contact information any time they speak with a customer by phone or in person. This includes confirming the physical and mailing address and any phone number or email contact information previously provided.

Purpose:
The purpose of this section is to provide guidance on the process when a Medi-Cal customer's mail is returned as undeliverable. This section was reformatted and renumbered.

Policy:
Upon receipt of returned mail or any indication that a customer has moved without reporting a change of address, staff must make reasonable attempts to contact the customer.

A. Phone Contact Requirements
When mail is received as undeliverable, staff must make at least two attempts to contact the customer by phone. If contact is made, staff must:
- Confirm the customer's address.
- Update the case address if necessary.
- Document the contact in a journal entry.

If unable to reach the customer on the first attempt or there is no phone number on file, staff must complete a detailed journal entry.

Returned Mail Information
When mail is returned, staff must ensure that it was sent to the intended address by reviewing the completeness and accuracy of the address on the returned mail and comparing it to the information on the customer's case record. If there are no errors or missing information, staff must attempt to contact the customer via two methods (ex. phone and mail). Complete a detailed journal entry.

If the original mail contains errors or missing information (ex. incorrect zip code, missing apartment number) or was not sent using the most up to date contact information, staff must correct the information and resend the documents to the corrected address. A detailed journal entry must be completed.

If mail is returned for any of the reasons below, staff must follow the procedures outlined in Processing Guide 46 - Address Discrepancies and Loss of Contact:
- An in-state address is received from a data source not identified as reliable.
- Conflicting addresses are received.
- An out-of-state address is received.
- Whereabouts are unclear due to undeliverable mail and no forwarding address is provided by the United States Postal Service (USPS).

Imaging Returned Mail

The contents or envelopes of undeliverable mail do not need to be imaged if the information is already stored in the California Statewide Automated Welfare System (CalSAWS). When mail is returned to the office as undeliverable, document the following in a detailed journal entry:

- Type of mail (NOA, form, letter, etc.,).
- Address the mail was sent to.
- Date the mail was sent.
- Date the mail was returned.
- Safe at Home (SAH) status if applicable, along with confirmation that the customer is utilizing the confidential post office (P.O.) Box.

90-Day Cure Period

Customers have 90 days from the date of discontinuance to have their Medi-Cal eligibility reestablished if their whereabouts become known and they remain in-state. Rescind eligibility back to the date of the discontinuance without requesting additional information to verify eligibility, unless there is other information that indicates that the customer may not meet all eligibility requirements.

Exempt From Discontinuance

Loss of contact is not a basis for discontinuing Medi-Cal benefits for the following programs:

- Former Foster Youth (FFY).
- Children eligible for Continuous Eligibility for Children (CEC).
- Deemed Eligible Infants (under 1 year).
- Medi-Cal Access Program (MCAP).
- Pregnant beneficiaries.
- Beneficiaries in their 12-month postpartum period.

Procedures:

Refer to Medi-Cal Processing Guide 46 for procedures on reviewing cases when an address discrepancy exists or there is a loss of customer contact.

Program Impacts:

CalFresh cases should not be discontinued for Whereabouts Unknown. When discontinuing Medi-Cal for one of the undeliverable mail situations above, ensure the action taken in CalSAWS does not affect the CalFresh benefits.

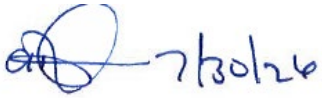
References:

MEDIL I23-11E
ACWDL 25-06

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Self-Sufficiency Services